

From: [Jan Garth](#)
To: [ostp-ai-rfi](#)
Subject: [External] Response to AI Action Plan RFI - Department of Labor Role
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Artificial intelligence, specifically generative AI, holds significant potential to revolutionize work, and the likely benefits of this technological revolution for employers are clear. However the impacts of AI on the American workforce are a critical consideration as the government crafts an AI Action Plan. Current estimates suggest between 5%-47% of American jobs may be affected by widespread automation via AI. While the body of research from which these estimates draw suggests that much remains unknown about how AI will reshape the American labor force, the overarching consensus is that AI will reshape the nature of work, and the skills required to obtain and maintain quality jobs.

The federal government's AI Action Plan can play a central role in ensuring that agencies are strategically positioned to both anticipate shifts in labor supply and demand and that agencies are able to swiftly respond to these shifts with reskilling and upskilling initiatives that serve to deepen America's impact on the AI landscape and enhance its competitiveness in the global economy.

The United States' Department of Labor's Employment and Training Administration (ETA) has a long history of providing workforce development training and resources to American job seekers throughout the United States and is uniquely positioned to predict and respond to emergent labor market changes with an aim to put the American worker first. ETA leverages its tested experience with building coalitions with educational institutions, proven and demonstrated development of employer-informed partnerships which have resulted in comprehensive curricula for emerging industries, and brings a strategic vantage point through its integration with workforce data, trends, and analysis.

EXISTING TOOLS AND STRATEGIES

- ETA administers (and supports states in administering) federal programs to empower American workers in the face of new technologies, including government job training, programs to support displaced workers and communities facing significant job losses, federal grants to states for public employment service programs, and UI programs.
- Services are available to workers and businesses through a network of nearly 2,300 American Job Centers nationwide.
- With adequate resources, the Department's current and historical programs can serve as important building blocks for addressing staggered, ongoing displacement and mass

displacement, and training the AI workforce of the future.

Preventing Displacement

- To win the future, organizations that prepare workers will need to invest in AI fluency and tech expertise for program participants and will need to be intentional about serving young adults.
- ETA has the WIOA Youth Program and in competitive grant programs that provide youth participants with opportunities for career exploration and skill development through (1) summer employment opportunities (2) pre-apprenticeship programs; (3) internships and job shadowing; and (4) on-the-job training.
- The **Youth Systems Building Academy** seeks to leverage the capacity of youth organizations to deploy innovative approaches, incorporate data and youth feedback and align local partners and investments to improve the supportive ecosystem for young people navigating the workforce.
- **Youth Build** is a community-based pre-apprenticeship program that provides job training and educational services for opportunity youth ages 16 to 24 who left school without a secondary diploma, providing connections to apprenticeship opportunities in the building trades, including emerging technologies such as AI. Adverse impacts of AI on workers' jobs are not inevitable and employers and businesses can proactively partner with the workforce system to prevent disruption among their workforces.
- The Department promotes **Layoff Aversion** strategies that support employers as they seek to retain and retrain incumbent workers for new roles through employer services and work-based learning opportunities, such as on-the-job training (OJT), Registered Apprenticeships, and incumbent worker training (IWT).

Supporting Workers Displaced by AI

- ETA has existing tools that can start to address staggered, ongoing displacement and potential swift, mass displacement caused by AI. These programs provide American workers with a critical safety net when they lose their job.
- WIOA's Dislocated Worker program is particularly well suited to serve individuals specifically displaced by AI. The Dislocated Worker program is designed to help dislocated workers get back to work as quickly as possible and overcome barriers to employment by providing services to assist those workers in re-entering the workforce.
- ETA promotes cyber and AI-related training through its competitive grant opportunities, including:
 - The **Strengthening Community Colleges (SCC) Training Grants**, which build the capacity of community colleges to address gaps that increase access to educational and economic opportunities for all American workers.
 - The **Apprenticeship Building America Grants Program**, which is designed to strengthen, modernize and expand the Registered Apprenticeship Program to enable more workers to earn while they learn and find reliable pathways to the middle class.
 - The **Building Pathways to Infrastructure Jobs Grant Program** develops replicable, comprehensive workforce strategies to prepare the workforce for middle- to high-skilled H-1B occupations within sectors identified as having potential for significant AI-related exposure.

Swift, Mass Displacement

- **Rapid Response** is a proactive and flexible strategy designed to respond to layoffs and plant closings by quickly coordinating services and providing immediate aid to companies and their affected workers, minimizing the disruptions to workers caused by job loss.
- “**Employment Recovery**” **Dislocated Worker Grants** are made available to states, Workforce Development Boards, Tribal governments, and similar eligible applicants to temporarily expand capacity to serve dislocated workers affected by major economic dislocations, such as plant closures, mass layoffs or closures of military bases.
- Workers who lose their jobs due to AI-driven displacement may turn to state UI systems to make ends meet while searching for new jobs. UI has long provided a critical safety net for workers who have lost a job for good cause or through no fault of their own, and it will be one of the first lines of support for workers displaced by AI.

Preparing the American Workforce System for an AI Economy

- ETA has already begun to prepare the workforce system for the challenges and opportunities ahead, including challenges posed by AI.
- **Expanding Access to UI through Modernization and Improved Customer Experience**
 - ETA has published strategies and resources to help states responsibly deploy technology and processes to improve service delivery, while also promoting access to benefits.
 - With the “earn-while-you-learn” model, which acknowledges employers as the drivers of their hiring and training, Registered Apprenticeships are uniquely situated to bring the potential for predictable and stable living wages to all members of local communities.
- ETA's **Job Corp** provides a well-timed opportunity to prepare our nation’s youth while building an AI-ready workforce through modernized Job Corps training programs.

ETA should participate in the AI Action Plan through AI workforce impact studies, training impacted workers, and leveraging the agency's experience and network to put American workers in the best position to navigate the AI workforce landscape.

J. Garth

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